

The Self Made High

An essay on Pride, Arrogance and Boasting (M08)

There is a single reality under all the words this family gathers — pride, arrogance, haughtiness, presumption, conceit, boasting. It is the self made high, or made much of. The vocabulary draws on one master image above all others: height. Pride is the self imagined spatially, lifted above its proper place — above other people, and finally above God. "Your heart be lifted up, and you forget the Lord your God" (Deu 8:14). "Everyone who is arrogant in heart is an abomination to the Lord" (Pro 16:5). And the most famous warning in Scripture about it is a warning about falling from a height: "Pride goes before destruction, and a haughty spirit before a fall" (Pro 16:18).

What makes this family more than a catalogue of bad attitudes is the One it is measured against. Pride is not, at root, a social failing or a personality flaw; it is a theological one. Exaltation, majesty and glory belong to God: "The Lord alone will be exalted in that day" (Isa 2:11, 17). Pride is the creature reaching for that — seizing what is not its to hold. This is why the same family of words that names human haughtiness also names, at its one legitimate point, "the majesty of the Lord" (Isa 26:10). Human pride is the counterfeit of a real and rightful divine height. Read pride only as psychology, and you lose its centre.

The lift and the settled height

The family begins in motion. Before pride is a condition it is an act — the active lifting of the self. Its sharpest portrait is a speech, the fivefold boast of the king of Babylon: "I will ascend to heaven... I will set my throne on high... I will make myself like the Most High" (Isa 14:13–14). It shows itself in the body — "how lofty are their eyes" (Pro 30:13) — but the lift is inward, an orientation of the whole person. And the lifting, repeated, settles. What begins as a motion hardens into a state: "the proud", "a haughty spirit", the entrenched loftiness of a person or a whole people — "the pride of Israel testifies to his face" (Hos 5:5). The seam where one becomes the other is visible in a single sentence about a great tree: "it towered high... its heart was proud of its height" (Eze 31:10). The act of rising becomes the condition of being high.

Over this settled pride stands the family's governing word, the sentence that fixes its whole meaning: "God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble" (Jam 4:6; 1Pe 5:5). Pride is the one disposition God is said to set himself against. And the conditions under which it takes hold are revealing: not hardship but its opposite — prosperity, strength, sufficiency. Uzziah was strong, "but when he was strong he grew proud, to his destruction" (2Ch 26:16). Sodom's pride is named alongside her "prosperous ease" (Eze 16:49). Pride is the sin of fullness.

Two directions of contempt

From that settled height, pride discharges outward — and it does so in two directions at once. Turned upward, it becomes presumption: acting above one's station against God or against the authority he has appointed. It is the prophet "who presumes to speak a word in my name that I have not commanded" (Deu 18:20); it is a nation that "has proudly defied the Lord" (Jer 50:29); it is those who, the New Testament says, "are bold and wilful... they despise authority" (2Pe 2:10). At its core this is a sin of the will — self-will set against an ordained limit.

Turned outward toward other people, the same disposition becomes insolence: contempt, derision, the strong despising the weak. We hear it mostly from underneath, in the voice of the one suffering it: "The insolent utterly deride me" (Psa 119:51); "Let not the insolent oppress me" (Psa 119:122). It overturns the proper order of honour — "the youth will be insolent to the elder" (Isa 3:5) — and it breeds conflict: "By insolence comes nothing but strife" (Pro 13:10). One disposition, two objects: God above, the neighbour beside. Both wound relationship, which is precisely what pride is least able to keep; the proud self, lifted up, holds the lowly in contempt (Psa 123:4).

The voiced form — and its two edges

Pride wants to be heard. Every mode of it has a voice — the "I will ascend" of self-exaltation, the presumptuous word, the derision of the insolent. But one of them *is* the voice: boasting, pride made audible. And here the family does something it does nowhere else. It splits in two by what it boasts *in*.

On one edge, boasting is the heart of the disease: glorying in flesh, in works, in riches, in one's own wisdom or might. "Let not the wise man boast in his wisdom... let not the rich man boast in his riches" (Jer 9:23). "Do not boast about tomorrow" (Pro 27:1). "All such boasting is evil" (Jam 4:16). On the other edge — and this is the hinge of the whole family — boasting is *commanded*: "Let the one who boasts, boast in the Lord" (1Cor 1:31; 2Cor 10:17). The difference is not the act but its direction. Glory referred to the self is pride; glory referred to God is worship. It is the one place in this family where the movement runs the other way — the height returned to the One it belongs to.

That redeemed boast carries everything the rest of the family cannot. It alone belongs to created design rather than the fall; it alone looks forward in hope — "we boast in hope of the glory of God" (Rom 5:2); it alone builds others up — "great is my pride in you" (2Cor 7:4); and it alone is at home in suffering. Where pride elsewhere is broken by affliction, this boast is perfected by it: "I will boast all the more gladly of my weaknesses, that the power of Christ may rest upon me" (2Cor 12:9); "we boast in our sufferings" (Rom 5:3). Pride's own logic is here turned inside out — the boast not in strength but in weakness, so that the strength may be God's.

The mind's swelling and the empty throne

Two further modes complete the picture. There is pride localised in the mind — not elevation so much as inflation. The New Testament names it with the image of a bellows: "this 'knowledge' puffs up, but love builds up" (1Cor 8:1); a man "puffed up with conceit" who "understands nothing" (1Ti 6:4). Its remedy is given in the same breath: "not to think of himself more highly than he ought to think" (Rom 12:3). It is worth noticing that the named opposite here is not humility but *love* — the swollen mind is cured by turning outward to build another up.

And there is the terminus, where the whole movement arrives: self-love, the self made its own centre and its own god. "People will be lovers of self" (2Ti 3:2); "In the pride of his face the wicked... says, 'There is no God'" (Psa 10:4). Its purest expression is a sentence that deliberately echoes God's own self-naming, now stolen by the creature: "I am, and there is no one besides me" (Isa 47:8, 10). Self-exaltation reaches *toward* God's place — "I will make myself like the Most High". Self-love simply *occupies* it. It is a small thing in the count of words and the decisive thing in meaning: the empty throne of the self, with God evicted.

The descent, and the one way down that saves

The family has one arc, and it is severe. Fullness gives rise to pride; pride lifts, settles, defies, and despises; and the end, every time, is to be brought low. "I will bring you down from there, declares the Lord" (Obd 4). "Ruin shall come upon you suddenly" (Isa 47:11). The fall comes as judgement, imposed and often abrupt — the height that the proud built collapsing under them.

There is only one way down that is not destruction, and it is to take it yourself, beforehand. Hezekiah, warned, "humbled himself for the pride of his heart" and the wrath was turned away (2Ch 32:26). Nebuchadnezzar learned, from the far side of his madness, the rule that governs the whole family: "those who walk in pride he is able to humble" (Dan 4:37). The choice the family sets before a person is finally simple — be lowered, or be brought low.

So the seven modes are one reality worked out in turn: the self lifted (self-exaltation), the self settled high (haughtiness), the self defiant toward God (presumption), the self contemptuous of others (insolence), the self displayed in speech (boasting), the self swollen in mind (conceit), and the self enthroned in God's place (self-love). The image throughout is height; the seat throughout is the heart; the occasion is fullness; the end is the fall. Against all of it stands its exact inverse — the boast that does not keep the glory but gives it back: "Let the one who boasts, boast in the Lord." That single counter-current is the family's way home. Pride is the creature's disordered grasp at what is God's. Right boasting is the same hand, opened, returning it.